Avoiding ‘dead air’

1 Speaking

Work with a partner and discuss the following questions.

- Are you good at meeting new people?
- When was the last time you met someone new? What did you talk about?
- When you meet someone for the first time, what kind of questions might you want to ask in:
  1. a social situation like a party
  2. a formal context like a business meeting?

2 Language

Unscramble the following to make questions.

1. you / with / things / how / are / ?

2. do / you / how / do / ?

3. your / flight / was / how / ?

4. going / how / is / job / your / ?

5. brothers / have / got / you / any / sisters / or / ?

6. come / where / you / do / from / ?

7. free / time / do / what / do / you / in / your / ?

8. like / do / doing / watching / you / sports / or / ?

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9. this / your / is / visit / first / to / Singapore / ?

10. hobbies / have / any / do / you / ?

11. work / whereabouts / you / do / ?

12. family / any / have / here / you / do / ?

3 Pronunciation

Listen to your teacher say the following sentences. Underline the stressed words and mark the weak forms (ə).

How are things with you?

How do you do?

Where do you come from?

Ask the questions to your partner.

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4 Listening

Listen to two friends talking about a boat race.

How does the first speaker signal that the conversation is finished?

Listen to two colleagues at work.

What does the first speaker suggest the other speaker should do?

What exactly does he say?

5 Language

Look at the list of phrases below. Write I if they are phrases for initiating conversation, and C if they are for closing a conversation.

__ How do you do?

__ How are things with you?

__ Bye for now.

__ Hi! My name's Jon. What's yours?

__ See you again.

__ Well. Lovely to meet you.

__ How's it going?

__ What's up?

__ I'm sorry, I've got to go now.

__ Have you got a minute?

__ It's been nice talking to you. Bye.

__ Excuse me. Sorry to bother you ...

Decide whether the phrases above are formal or informal.

Listen to your teacher say the phrases and repeat them.

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6 Speaking

Imagine someone you don't know very well is coming to visit. They don't know anything about your town/city and they want some advice on places to go and things to do. Think of places they could go.

e.g. go to the zoo
watch horse racing

7 Language

Below are some phrases we can use for giving suggestions and advice. Use some of the ideas you thought of to make sentences about your hometown.

e.g. You should go to the zoo.
Try watching horse racing.

You should ...
You could ...
How about ...
Try ... (ing)
Why don't you ...
One thing I recommend is ...
Have you tried ....(ing)
..... is really good/ amazing
You should definitely ...
If I were you, I would/ wouldn't

Use the phrases above to make suggestions to a partner.

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8 Speaking

Speak to as many people in the class as you can.

Role play 1:
A new co-worker has started at your company. He/she is new to town, and would like some advice on what to do in your town/city on weekends off. Discuss hobbies and free time activities that are possible.

Role play 2:
You are at a friend's house, and you have just sat down next to someone you don't know.
Find out about them and what they have done in your town/city or what they would like to do.
Also find out where they have travelled in the region or would like to travel.

Remember to use phrases for initiating and closing a conversation.

When you have finished write down what you can remember about TWO of the people you spoke to.

Name	
Occupation	
Interests	
Family	
Hometown	

Work in a group. Tell your group members about the two people you spoke to. Can you remember the place they suggested you visit?

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